
I've Learned One Magical Thing From Soccer Commentators. You Can Try It, Too.

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Clement Gelly

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In one of my first months in São Paulo, Brazil, a taxi driver switched on the radio. It was a soccer game, and suddenly the game's announcer was blasting out words in Portuguese like a firehose. *X passes to Y, Y runs up the wing—the pitch and speed mounting—challenge from defender A but Y dribbles past, now he's taking a long cross—pitch and speed crescendoing—it's headed for Z who goes for the header—peak flow—but it's blooocked by defender B—the last syllable of the name trailing off—and it's a corner now—the speech slowing into an analysis of the play and then mounting back up as the action continued.* In 10 seconds.

The sheer pressure of the words pinned me back against my seat. The announcer was speaking faster than I'd thought humanly possible, while still making complete sense. It wasn't just sense, it was artistry. I was familiar with English-language commentary on television—the sometimes dry, sometimes poetic British, and the strained and pedantic Americans. But television commentary is inherently more sparse than radio commentary, in order to allow the images to speak for themselves. The radio announcer, on the other hand, needs to fill everything. And in Brazil, this has been elevated to the level of art—the general population knows the narrators' names, they all have their favorites, and sometimes they turn off the sound on the TV in order to overlay a more dynamic radio commentary. There's even a section in São Paulo's Museum of Football dedicated to the country's most famous commentators.

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In the taxi, I heard the commentator describe the movement of the ball across the pitch, the names of the players, the passes and feints and tackles. In the pace and tenor of his voice, he held the emotion and energy of the game, the rising tension of an approach, the dashed hopes of a shot gone wide, the frenetic movement of tight passes, and the long arc of a surprise through ball.

I especially admired his fluency because my own Portuguese was so stunted. I reached so many blank spots in my vocabulary and dead ends in my grammatical constructions that I often preferred to remain silent. It was satisfying to hear someone rattle it out with such grace. But more than that, I admired the announcer's ability to describe exactly what was happening in the very moment it was happening, without confusion or delay—like the sail of a ship converting the world's motion into his own. My inarticulacy in Portuguese was symptomatic of a broader failure to express myself at all, I felt, even to myself.

In the preceding year and change living in Las Vegas, I had gone through some horrible experiences, including being locked down in a school shooting and a drug-related hospitalization. Coming to Brazil for work and for a romantic relationship in the aftermath, I had found myself stultified and listless. I wasn't interested in anything and I couldn't figure out why. I needed something to pull myself back into the world, but I was too stuck to figure out what. And talking

about what had happened with friends or in therapy, which I didn't like to do, didn't solve the problem either. There was some kind of interminable "[tiki-taka](#)" in the midfield of my psyche that defied me. But maybe, if I could learn to put words to it, something would change. And who better to ask than a soccer announcer, one so expert in describing things the moment that they happen? Could these descriptive capacities be turned inward, to commentate the mind?

So I got in contact with Brazilian soccer announcer Fernando Camargo. He has more than 15 years' experience with sports narration across both radio and television, and he told me he's narrated more than 73 different types of sporting events including tennis, rugby, basketball, and more. (The most difficult is Olympic shooting competitions, he said, because almost nothing happens.) In one of his soccer commentary highlight reels on YouTube, I counted him speaking 71 syllables in nine seconds. Camargo is a landmark of football narration—in the café where we met, someone recognized him based on his voice alone.

To be a good announcer, Camargo told me, you have to be a curious person. You have to keep studying the world—not just player bios and game statistics, but everything, because all of it improves your ability to narrate a football game. Your vocabulary and the information you have is your whole repertoire, and you never know where a particular word or idea from a completely unrelated topic might elevate your descriptions to another level.

There was really only one way to actually get good at it, he said. You have to practice. Practice, practice, practice. Even when he was 8 or 9 years old, he would narrate his friends' foosball games, borrowing phrases he'd heard on the radio. Later he would narrate soccer games on TV with the sound off. Later on still, he would record himself, listen back, record again. He would narrate any chance he could. It doesn't even matter what it is, he told me. He looked out the window.

"*Passing now is a Chevrolet car, accelerating now up to 45 kilometers an hour,*" he rattled out in half a second in Portuguese, "*turning onto the road to the right and that woman is waiting, waiting to enter the supermarket,*" he said, tension rising, "*she takes out her wallet, she takes it out to make her payment, she's going to buy those biscuits!*"

I looked turned around to see, very distantly, a woman place a tube of biscuits in her purse and walk off.

"When you're speaking, it seems like more stuff is happening," I told him, laughing. "If it were me describing it ..."

He laughed too. "But there's always lots of stuff happening," he said.

To get me started on my own internal commentating, he gave me an assignment. "On your way back home on the metro, just try to describe everything you're seeing. The people getting on and off, what they look like, what they're doing, what they're wearing. Just do it in your head, in English. You'll get the hang of it."

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He gave me a lift to the metro station, and I walked down the escalator already trying to narrate what I was seeing. A man is rubbing his eye, he's rubbing his left eye, underneath his glasses. I'm entering the train. A child is giggling and running away from his mom and sister. The doors close. The mom sends the sister after him, and the sister drags him back, and the mom pulls his ear. The metro pulls into the next station. The eye-rubber gets out. Another guy gets on with a Metallica shirt, and he has a nose piercing and an eyebrow piercing.

In every moment, there was too much going on to describe it all. I felt my brain churning, shaking off some rust. I'd stopped trying to understand myself and focused outward. For the first time in a year, I was present in the world around me.

With the World Cup on now, I've immersed myself in the barrage of narration, catching three or four games a day at home and with friends and in bars. And sometimes when I'm alone, to feel that presence again, I'll switch the sound off to try to narrate it myself. With practice, as Camargo assured me I would, I've gotten a little better. The technique is not a panacea—not an instant goal. But it brings some energy to the sluggish starting 11 of my mind. It makes some space in a tight defense, finds gaps to pass more dynamically, gets the ball up the field. It sends a nice long cross into the box for a header toward the back of the net.

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